Lesson 11: Critical Reading: Reading Response Journals and Prereading

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 1.1: Introduction; 1.2: Sample Reading Response Journal- an Undocumented Teacher's Story; 1.3: Identifying Reading Strategies and Prereading a Text.

In this lesson

Unit 2 is about critical reading: reading actively and turning what you read into evidence for your own writing. In this lesson you will study a model reading response journal on an undocumented teacher's story, "Deport Me", and practise two prereading strategies, the 4 Ps and the KWL+ chart. These habits help you read long university texts, such as PSYC 110 lecture transcripts and textbook chapters, with a clear purpose.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a reading response journal is and how each entry is built.
- Use the 4 Ps (purpose, preview, prior knowledge, predict) before reading a textbook passage.
- Complete a KWL+ chart before and after reading.
- Introduce a quotation with the author's name and a reporting verb.
- Write a reading response journal with three entries.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
reading response journal (also "dialectic journal")	a set of entries; each has a quotation from a reading and your response to it	It is a common assignment in ESL and English courses.
quotation	the exact words of a text, inside quotation marks	Record each part as a quotation.
reflection / connection / analysis	thinking about your reaction / linking the text to your life, other texts or the world / studying how and why the text works	Respond with a few sentences of reflection, connection, or analysis.
preview	look quickly at a text before reading it, to get the big picture	Think of previewing a text like watching a movie trailer.
prior knowledge	what you already know about a topic	Based on your background, what do you know about the topic?

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
predict	say what you expect a text to be about	What do you expect the reading to be about?
KWL+	a chart: what I Know, what I Want to know, what I Learned, + what I still want to know	Complete the first two columns before you read.
undocumented immigrant	a person who lives in a country without legal papers	Grande has written extensively about living in the U.S. as an undocumented immigrant.
deportation	removal from a country because a person lacks legal papers	Families face the constant threat of deportation.
self-fulfilling prophecy	an expectation that comes true because people act as if it were true (also a term in psychology)	"... like all self-fulfilling prophecies, I got to the point where my grades reflected what society said ..."
empathy	understanding and sharing another person's feelings	This description immediately builds empathy with the reader.
recalls / explains / writes / reports	reporting verbs that introduce a quotation	Fuentes-Mena recalls, "At age eight, I started going to work with my dad ..." (par 1).

Rules and explanations

Reading and writing go together

- We engage actively with a text to build meaning, and we use texts as evidence in our writing. Evidence can come from other texts, our personal life, podcasts or TED talks.
- The theme is immigration in the U.S., especially undocumented immigrants. Many crossed the U.S.-Mexican border without legal papers, or arrived by plane and overstayed their visas.

The reading response journal

- The usual assignment: choose a few parts of the reading that stand out to you, record each one as a quotation, and respond to each with a few sentences of reflection, connection or analysis.
- It can be informal (your reactions and experiences), formal (text analysis), or both. Your job is to find the parts that are significant to you and build meaning from the text and your own experience.
- The model (Table 1.2.1) has three columns: Entry number | Quotation | Response.
- The quotation column: author's last name + reporting verb + comma + exact quotation + paragraph number: Fuentes-Mena recalls, "At age eight, I started going to work with my dad ..." (par 1). An introductory phrase can come first: "Describing his adolescent frustration, Fuentes-Mena writes, ..."
- Lesson 15 returns to this journal to study its analysis, square brackets [ ] and ellipses (. . .).

Prereading strategy 1: the 4 Ps

Step	What to ask or do
Purpose	Why am I reading this? What must I do with it: answer questions, prepare for a test, use ideas in an essay?
Preview	Get the big picture: check the title and headings; look for the main idea in the first paragraph; check the last paragraph; read the first sentence of every paragraph; examine graphic aids (images, graphs, diagrams); look for bold or highlighted key terms.
Prior knowledge	What do I already know about the topic or the author?
Predict	From my overview, what will the reading be about? What is the writer trying to say?

Prereading strategy 2: KWL+

K	W	L	+
What I Know (before reading)	What I Want to know (before reading)	What I Learned (during or after reading)	What I still want to know (after reading)

- For K and W, use the title, the author's name and the topic. Write sentences, questions or connections.
- In research, the + column becomes your list of questions to investigate next.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no capital letters, so check capitals when you copy a quotation or a title: Fuentes-Mena, Ms. Kovacic, Teach for America, The Distance Between Us. - In your responses, avoid one long sentence joined with "and ... and ... and". The model responses make one clear point per sentence.

Practice

Exercise 1. Your reading strategies. What reading strategies do you use now? For example, do you look at the title and subheadings first? Do you take notes as you read? Write a list of at least five (the book asks for a class list; make your own). Mark the ones that belong to the 4 Ps.

Exercise 2. Pre-read with the 4 Ps. Use the 4 Ps with the textbook excerpt "Undocumented Families" (from *Immigrant and Refugee Families*) in the lesson material. Do steps 1-4 before you read the whole text.

1. Purpose: Why are you reading this text?
2. Preview: What do the title, the first paragraph, the first sentence of each paragraph, the picture and the key term tell you?
3. Prior knowledge: What do you already know about this topic?
4. Predict: What do you expect the reading to be about?
5. Now read the text. Which previewing strategies did you use? Was your prediction correct?

Exercise 3. KWL+ with a memoir. Use the excerpt from *The Distance Between Us* by Reyna Grande in the lesson material.

1. Draw a KWL+ chart. Before reading, complete the K and W columns from the title, the author's name and the topic of undocumented immigrants.
2. Read the excerpt. Then complete the L and + columns.
3. How could you use KWL+ when you do your own research? (Share your chart with your tutor instead of a partner.)

Exercise 4. Read "Deport Me" and the model journal. Read "Deport Me" by Alejandro Fuentes-Mena (Motus Theater) in the lesson material.

1. As you read, notice which parts stand out to you. Which quotations would you choose? What would you say about them? Write down two.
2. Now read the four entries in Table 1.2.1. Which entry is mainly a personal connection? Which entries mainly analyze the author's language?
3. Which reporting verb introduces the quotation in each entry?
4. Entry 3 says that Fuentes-Mena uses repetition, parallel structure and rhyme. Find the three pairs of phrases it quotes.

Speak with your tutor

- "I am going to preview a PSYC 110 lecture transcript with the 4 Ps. Ask me the four questions one by one, and tell me if my prediction is reasonable."
- "Here is my KWL+ chart for *The Distance Between Us*: [paste]. Help me write better questions for the + column."
- "Let's discuss the chapter's questions: What challenges do undocumented immigrants face? What misconceptions do other people have about them? Ask me for evidence from 'Deport Me' for each answer."
- "Read entry 3 of the sample journal with me. Ask me to explain, in my own words, how repetition and sentence length create meaning."

Read aloud

Read the repeated structures with the same rhythm, and pause at each full stop.

1. You can only understand people if you feel them in yourself. (John Steinbeck)
2. One hundred dollars that she saw as a blessing. One hundred dollars that I saw as an attack on our family.
3. I began making jokes rather than making plans for my future. Playing games rather than paying attention. Chasing girls rather than chasing my dreams.
4. And we are four whole, beautiful gifts, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all. (He echoes the U.S. Pledge of Allegiance.)
5. Deport me. But in the end, it's your loss.

6. Word stress: un·DOC·u·ment·ed, de·por·TA·tion, EM·pa·thy, PROPH·e·cy, PRE·view, pre·DICT.

Writing task

A reading response journal. Write three entries (about 300-400 words in total). Use the 4 Ps or a KWL+ chart before you read. Choose one text:

- "Deport Me" (choose quotations that are different from the four model entries);
- the excerpt from *The Distance Between Us*;
- a psychology text: one section of a PSYC 110 lecture transcript, for example Lecture 8, Chapter 5, "The Power of Suggestion on Memory", or Lecture 20, Chapter 4, "Getting Used to Happiness".

Each entry has a Quotation part and a Response part (60-120 words). At least one response analyzes the writer's language (a contrast, a repetition, a word choice, sentence length), and at least one makes a connection to your life, another text or the world.

Checklist:

- Each quotation is copied exactly, in quotation marks, with the original capitals and punctuation.
- Each quotation is introduced with a name and a reporting verb (recalls, explains, writes, reports), with a paragraph number if the text has them.
- Each response adds something: it reflects, connects or analyzes; it does not only repeat the quotation.
- At least one response explains how the writer's words create meaning.
- Your sentences are complete, and you do not join many ideas with "and".
- If you write about a lecture, you name the speaker (for example, Professor Paul Bloom) and the lecture title.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (example answer) I look at the title and subtitles first (preview). I check how long the text is. I read the first and last paragraphs (preview). I think about what I already know (prior knowledge). I underline new words.

Exercise 2

1. (example answer) To practise the 4 Ps and to learn what barriers undocumented families face, so that I can use the ideas in a discussion or an essay.
2. The title: the text is about families without legal papers. The first paragraph gives the main idea: for some families, legal immigration is very limited, and families who travel to the U.S. face "substantial barriers": a perilous trip across the border, few resources and the constant threat of deportation. The first sentence of the second paragraph: the trip across the border is one of the most dangerous times. The picture: a woman holding a sign that says "Courage" at an immigration march. The key term: "deportation", defined in the first paragraph. The numbers and the citation (ICE, 2019) show that the text uses statistics.
3. (example answer) Many people try to cross the border from Mexico without papers, and the journey can be dangerous.
4. (example answer) The text will describe the dangers undocumented families face, especially at the border, with statistics.
5. (example answer) I used the title, the first paragraph, the first sentences and the picture, and my prediction was correct. Check the facts: in 2014, ICE carried out 315,943 removals, and 67% of these people were taken into custody at the border; Unicef estimates that more than 3,800 people have died crossing since 2014; more than 2,600 children were separated from their caregivers under a policy that was later overturned.

Exercise 3

1. (example answer) K: Reyna Grande is a Mexican-American author who crossed the border as a child. W: Why is the book called *The Distance Between Us*? How did she cross? What happened to her family?
2. L: check your notes against the text. The first two attempts failed, and she blames herself. On the first, she had a toothache and a fever, her father carried her on his back, and border patrol agents found them in the bushes and sent them back to Tijuana. On the second, she found a dead man; her sister Mago told her, "He's sleeping, Nena." They were caught soon after, and she was glad. ("La migra" is Spanish slang for immigration officers; the "coyote" is the person paid to guide them.) The book's introduction adds that they crossed safely on the third attempt. +: (example answer) How did they cross the third time? How did she feel about her father?
3. (example answer) Before researching, I can list what I know and want to know, so that I search with clear questions. After reading a source, the + column gives me questions for my next search.

Exercise 4

1. (example answer) "One hundred dollars that she saw as a blessing. One hundred dollars that I saw as an attack on our family." The same amount of money means opposite things to the mother and the son.
2. Entry 4 is mainly a personal connection: the journal writer compares Ms. Kovacic with their own teacher, Professor Lee. Entries 1, 2 and 3 mainly analyze language: the contrast and symbol of "home" (1), the repeated "Despite the fact ..." (2), and repetition, rhyme and sentence length (3).
3. Entry 1: recalls. Entry 2: explains. Entry 3: writes. Entry 4: reports.
4. "making jokes" / "making plans"; "playing games" / "paying attention"; "chasing girls" / "chasing [his] dreams".

My notes